



FOOD FOR THOUGHT

Ryan Fernando



FOR MORE
STORIES

When sunscreen needs a backup

For athletes who train outdoors, sunscreen is only **part of the equation.** The right foods can support skin, hair, iron stores and recovery.

Every few weeks, someone sits across from me with the same story. Six months of serious outdoor training. Timings are better, body fat is down, the clothes fit. And yet the hairline has crept back and the face in recent photographs looks tired in a way it did not last year. They blame stress, or age, or the water in their building. Nine times out of 10, however, the answer is sitting on their plate.

When you train hard in the sun, your body sends nutrients to muscle repair, red blood cell production and immunity before anything else. Your follicles and skin barrier live on what is left over. If your diet is merely average, nothing is left over.

Here is what I actually look at with athletes who train outdoors:

Your sweat is taking out more than water

You lose sodium and potassium, and smaller amounts of zinc and iron. Add the red blood

cell damage from repeated foot strike in runners and gut losses in endurance athletes, and iron stores can drop quietly over a season.

This is why I ask for ferritin and not just haemoglobin. I see athletes with perfectly normal haemoglobin sitting on ferritin levels in the teens, and that is exactly where the shedding begins. For women running or cycling long distances, I want ferritin comfortably above 50. Build it back with mutton, liver, chicken and fish, or, for vegetarians, with ragi, rajma, greens and dates. Eat something containing

